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The operation of grade retention and educational inequality: who gets retained in Macao and why?

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ABSTRACT
While the existence of a class, gender, or ethnic gap in educational attainment is well documented for many societies, how the practice of grade retention contributes to these patterns of educational inequality has been inadequately addressed. Given that grade retention is commonly practised in Macao, Macao is used as a case for illustration. Using data from PISA 2009 and a qualitative research project, we seek to demonstrate how inadequate state regulation could make possible the manipulation of grade retention institutionally and individually in Macao. This, in turn, illustrates how the specific contextualized structural operation of grade retention could serve as a mechanism for social differentiation and thus play a role in contributing to the observed educational inequality.

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Introduction

In order to make sense of a well-documented class, gender, or ethnic gap in educational attainment reported for many industrial-capitalist societies (Grusky, 2008; Schofer & Meyer, 2005; Torres & Antikainen, 2003), the roles of such common practices at school as tracking and ability-grouping have been examined and widely debated (Beru et al., 2007; Eccles & Midgley, 1990; Hallinan, 2000; Oakes, 2005; Sharp & Green, 1984; Woods, 1990). But, the roles of another common practice of grade retention in understanding the observed patterns of educational inequality do not seem to receive as much attention. Given that the practice of grade retention is widespread in Macao, whose accumulative rate of grade retention is the second highest among all participating regions – over 40% of 15-year-olds in Macao having been retained – according to the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) 2009 conducted by the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), Macao could serve as a case for illustration.

To this end, we shall refer to data from PISA 2009 and from a qualitative research project about educational inequality in Macao. In what follows, we shall first review studies on grade retention, highlighting that its role in explaining the observed gaps in educational attainment has been inadequately addressed. And then, we shall provide an overview of the Macao education system and draw out its specific characteristics so that readers could understand better the context against which grade retention operates in Macao. After that, we shall discuss the data used in this paper. With all this background information, we shall move on to discuss how grade retention operates in Macao, and analyse who gets retained in Macao and why it is so; this then enables us to understand how the practice of grade retention could play a role in explaining the observed gaps in educational attainment.

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Studies on Grade retention and educational inequality

In view of well-documented educational gaps, a number of explanations have been advanced over these years (Moore, 2004). However, the relevance of the practice of grade retention to making sense of the observed educational gaps has been inadequately discussed. Grade retention is the practice of requiring a student of a given grade to remain in that grade for a subsequent school year. The major focus of the discussion over grade retention, mostly based on data for the USA, is on the efficacy of such practice as an intervention strategy looking into its short-term and long-term impact on student learning (Holmes, 1989; Jimerson, 2001; Jimerson & Kaufman, 2003; Owings & Magliaro, 1998).

It is reported that grade retention would demotivate students, hamper their self-esteem, and make them disengage from school activities (Jimerson, Carlson, Rotert, Egeland, & Sroufe, 1997; Roderick & Nagaoka, 2005), and that grade retention is a significant predictor of dropping out of high school (Roderick, 1994; Stearns, Moller, Blau, & Potochnick, 2007). But, the effectiveness of grade retention as an intervention strategy remains debatable in Macao, where many teachers still believe that grade retention helps improve students' academic performance. In examining grade retention as an intervention strategy, these studies do not take grade retention as a mechanism for social differentiation, investigating how it operates so as to play a part in producing the observed educational gaps. But, with collective effort, it is found that male and/or ethnic minority students and/or students coming from a disadvantaged social class family are more likely to get retained (Jimerson, Anderson, & Whipple, 2002; Ream & Rumberger, 2008). So, we can infer from this that disadvantaged-class male ethnic minority students are more likely to get retained in the first place, subsequently are more likely to drop out of high school, and consequently are more likely to attain a lower level of education. However, we still do not know much about how structural forces impact on the operation of grade retention in a specific context. Besides, such discussion, however inadequate in addressing the issue of educational inequality, is essentially about the situation in the USA or Europe. Attention has rarely been paid to Asia. This paper seeks to fill in this gap by referring to Macao – a city in Asia – as a case for illustration. This then leads us to the Macao education system.

The Macao education system

Macao was under Portuguese rule between 1887 and 1999. During the colonial time, basic education for the local Chinese in Macao was ignored by the Portuguese. This colonial neglect of local education had implications for the provision of education and for teacher training. Basic education was provided by the civil society: private schools funded and managed by a variety of organizations, such as individuals, religious institutions, trading associations, neighbourhood associations, lineage associations, and the Federation of Labour Union (Clayton, 2009). And institutionalized teacher training essentially did not exist in Macao until the early 1980s but had to rely on the People's Republic of China (PRC) or Taiwan for provision. Without getting much governmental support, private schools had only meagre funding for operation. As a result, most could not create a quality learning environment; neither could they afford to hire qualified teachers. Most teachers did not have training in education; only very few had a bachelor's degree or received teacher training from the PRC or Taiwan and later on from Hong Kong. In fact, the professionalism of teachers in Macao was still a concern even in the late 1980s, when only about 30% of teachers were qualified to teach (Wong, 1991). So, the quality of basic education could vary tremendously across schools; and the general quality of education in Macao could also be in doubt.

However, without getting much governmental support, private schools were basically exempted from regulation enjoying autonomy in nearly every aspect: they could have their own policies of teacher hiring and student recruitment, and set their own rules and regulations and also academic standards. Literally, private schools could hire whoever they considered as qualified; meanwhile, private schools could also fire whoever they considered as unqualified. This situation remained broadly the same before the 1999 handover, despite some governmental regulation on teacher recruitment of private schools in the 1990s. In other words, while teachers' professionalism was in doubt, teachers in private schools were

actually in a vulnerable position, being treated by their schools not as professionals but dispensable employees. And, there was simply no coordination among private schools; so, there was no common curriculum or standardized examination at each educational stage (Bray, 1992). Without common/standardized examinations in Macao and thus having no readily available indicators to demonstrate their quality to potential students, private schools set their own academic standards and usually relied on grade retention rate in order to compete for students. In short, the practice of grade retention has then become widespread.

There has been a drastic increase in governmental investment in education since the 1999 handover and the setup of the Macao Special Administrative Region (SAR) government. However, despite this increase, there are no dramatic changes in situations for students and teachers. Nowadays, there are more than 95% of students in Macao studying in private schools doing different curricula without taking any standardized examination at the end of basic education. A significant proportion – some 20% – of teachers was still unqualified to teach, according to a study about the professionalism of teachers in Macao conducted in 2007 (the website of Macao DSEJ), although more monetary incentives in the form of monthly allowances from the government have been given to encourage teachers to read a certificate/diploma in education since the passing of the legal framework for regulating teachers hired by private schools in March 2012. Yet, teachers still remain in a vulnerable position: they are hired on a yearly contract basis; and, private schools could fire them at any time without notifying them in advance, even for an unreasonable reason, as long as they provide them with a legally required amount of compensation. Put simply, the Macao education system remains a system of private schools whereby much of the Macao SAR government's responsibility lies on regulation of school practices and funding allocation (according to the number of students recruited for each class).

In order to survive in a system whereby the amount of governmental funding for each school very much ties to student enrolment, private schools still have to compete for students and remain reliant on grade retention to build their reputation. The practice of grade retention, despite being hotly debated in the 1990s, was not seriously challenged until the release of PISA results on retention rates. As a colonial legacy, there are, without exaggeration, over a hundred different policies for grade retention at school level (*Macao Daily* 12 November 2012). And, whenever the government seeks to tighten its regulation, private schools would strongly defend their practices, including the practice of grade retention, in the name of their autonomy guaranteed by the Basic Law. Against such a system of private schools whereby the professionalism of teachers is somehow in doubt and teachers are in such a vulnerable position vis-a-vis private schools, we argue that the operation of grade retention in Macao could be institutionally manipulated by private schools and their teachers. This is the context against which the role of grade retention in understanding educational inequality is examined. To this end, we shall draw on relevant quantitative and qualitative data.

Data about Macao

In order to address the issue set out here, we shall rely on two types of data: quantitative statistics and qualitative material. By referring to data from PISA 2009, we seek to offer general patterns of educational inequality with respect to grade retention in Macao. PISA is a study conducted by the OECD examining the performance of 15-year-olds on reading, mathematics, and science in over 70 countries and regions. In each region/country, it collects statistically representative data regarding student background and academic performance, and school environment. PISA is administered on a 3-year cycle since 2000. Macao started to join PISA in 2003. We use data from PISA 2009 to solicit information from a student questionnaire; Table 1 summarizes the demographic information and performance of Macao students at PISA 2009.

With a view to understanding the operation of grade retention and its relation to educational inequality, it is necessary to examine the criteria for grade retention set by schools in black and white and to examine what happens in the classroom and/or at school. So, in addition to PISA data, we shall draw on some data from a separate qualitative research project on educational inequality in Macao

Table 1. Description of PISA-Macao 2009 sample.

	Number of students
PISA student sample[a]	5952
Male	3011
Female	2941
PISA target student population[a]	5969
Macao PISA 2009 average score[b]	
Reading	487
Mathematics	525
Science	511
International average score	
Reading	500
Mathematics	500
Science	500

[a]OECD (2012).
[b]OECD (2010).

Table 2. Research material of the qualitative study used for this paper.

Part of the qualitative study	Schools run by traditional organizations	Catholic schools	Other schools[a]	Govern-ment schools	Total
School regulations	15 secondary schools	16 secondary schools	9 secondary schools	3secondary schools	43 secondary schools
Focus-group interviews					
with students	5 students (1 focus group)	19 students (3 focus groups)	5 students (1 focus group)		29 students (5 focus groups)
with teachers	9 teachers (2 focus groups)	8 teachers (2 focus groups)	7 teachers (2 focus groups)		24 teachers (6 focus groups)

[a]Other schools refer to seven schools organized by the Christian Church, one Buddhist school, and one international school.

that the first author has been conducting since 2009. While there are three major study targets – texts, students, and teachers – and five parts in this project, for the present purposes we shall draw on two parts of the project: as described in Table 2, the first is school regulations, specifically those about the criteria for grade retention set by all 43 secondary schools in Macao; and, the second is material from focus-group interviews with students and teachers on their views on school regulations in general and grade retention in particular. Schools are categorized into four types with reference to the similarity of their school regulations. Students aged 15 or above and teachers were recruited for focus-group interviews according to school type; and, focus-group interviews were arranged for students and for teachers respectively between April and June 2013. Given that there are only three government schools in Macao, unfortunately no teachers or students could be recruited from schools of this type. In the end, 29 students and 24 teachers were recruited for focus-group interviews. A focus-group interview was arranged for every five to eight students or for every three to five teachers from the same school type; in total, five focus-group interviews were conducted for students and six for teachers. Each focus-group interview took about two hours; the interviews were transcribed and translated from English into Cantonese, the major local dialect in Macao. The data from the focus-group interviews are analysed thematically: their perceived purposes of grade retention and school regulations and their respective effectiveness.

Using PISA data, we seek to calculate statistics related to grade retention by various demographic characteristics of students. To simplify calculation, we classify students into two groups using self-reported data: those who have never repeated a grade at primary or lower secondary level or those who have. Then we employ statistical tests to test the statistical significance of observed differences between the two groups of students. Using qualitative material, we seek to illustrate processes underlying such observed statistical patterns. Taken together, statistical patterns are demonstrated and then supplemented with qualitative material to illustrate the ways through which the operation of grade

retention in Macao could be seen as serving as a mechanism for social differentiation underlying the observed class, gender, or ethnic gap in educational attainment. We argue that the quantitative and qualitative data used for this paper could enable us to address effectively the issues set out here.

Discussion and analysis

In Macao, grade retention is seen as a well-meaning practice in helping students to strengthen their academic foundation and a high retention rate is taken as a synonym for quality assurance of education (clippings from *Macao Daily* 2011–2012; opinions of parents on a forum). Indeed, such view towards grade retention is also expressed by many students and teachers in the focus-group interviews reported here; the following two quotations are typical views expressed in the focus-group interviews.

> The practice of grade retention is good for it makes sure that every student who gets promoted is up to the standards. (male student OS1, from an "other" school)

> Grade retention is practised for students' benefits … Otherwise, Macao would have been like Hong Kong, where all students automatically get promoted grade by grade. … Without grade retention, how can we be sure that students are up to standards? (male teacher CT4, from a Catholic school, received a local teaching diploma)

Given such prevalent view that grade retention is for quality assurance of education, one would have thought that academic ability is the most determining factor in deciding whether students would get retained and therefore the level of the set academic standards is crucial to understanding why students get retained. This may lead one to argue that grade retention is merely a screening device selecting the most academically capable students stage by stage; and so, its role in educational inequality is rather straightforward: it serves as a meritocratic mechanism for social selection. However, what our data reveal is more complicated than this.

The operation of grade retention in Macao

Before going on to discuss who gets retained and why they get retained, we need to understand how grade retention operates in Macao. Let us first take a look at school regulations concerning the criteria for retention in Macao. Table 3 summarizes the criteria for grade retention set by all 43 secondary schools in Macao.

Table 3 shows that there are two major criteria for grade retention: academic performance and conduct. However, as discussed above, given the colonial legacy there is no consensus on what academic standards students in Macao have to live up to in order to get promoted to the next grade. Rather, the so-called academic standards vary tremendously across schools: schools set different passing marks, assign weightings to different subjects, and require students to be retained if they fail a certain number of weighted subjects, ranging from failing a unit of one subject to failing six subjects. What such diverse practices of schools imply is not merely that academic standards upheld by different schools are not comparable, but that grade retention is practised in such a manner as leaving much room for discretion by schools, thus institutional manipulation. Given that governmental funding still ties to student enrolments, private schools still have to compete for students. A teacher made it crystal clear in a focus-group interview that the rate of grade retention was exploited by many schools – more precisely by school principals – as a device to boost up their reputation.

> Most schools are private schools here and their survival depends on student enrolment. Then, how could schools attract students, actually their parents? No one wants to admit it, but it's an open secret that many school principals use grade retention as a device to get rid of so-called poor students so as to boost their school reputation. … Some years ago, when a principal increased drastically the retention rate retaining a great number of students who would have been promoted in many schools, the principal was severely criticized for sacrificing students' futures for the sake of building up the school reputation. Just a few years' time, this school has become one of the top schools in Macao that many parents desperately want to send their children there; now, who still remember those severe criticisms? … Many school principals actually follow suit in the hope that they could soon boost up their school reputations. (male teacher TT2, from a school run by a traditional organization, received a local teaching diploma)

Table 3. A summary of the criteria for grade retention set by 43 secondary schools.

Criterion	Remarks
Academic performance	
1. Passing marks	• Schools set different passing marks, ranging from 40 to 60 out of 100 marks
2. Weighting	• All except eight schools differentiate core subjects from the others or give more weighting (e.g., a greater number of units) to core subjects • The Chinese language, the English language, and Mathematics are usually three core subjects or subjects with double weightings
3. Passing standards	• Students are allowed to fail a set number of weighted subjects without being retained • This number ranges from one unit of a core subject to six peripheral subjects • seven schools require students to repeat a grade if they fail the same subject in two consecutive years
Conduct	• Poor conduct (e.g., below grade B or C) could lead to grade retention in 10 schools
Special school practice: Maximum number of grade retention allowed	• True, all except seven schools do not set the maximum number of retention • But, six schools allow students to get retained only once; when asked to be retained for the second time (not necessarily in the following year), students should quit the school • About half of the schools ask students to quit the school when the students are to repeat the same grade again in a consecutive year

Source: Adapted from Wong (2013), Table 6.

What is also of relevance is the following practice (expressed in focus-group interviews with teachers): for the sake of convenience, many schools usually assign the same teacher to teach the same subject to students of the same grade. In operation, this teacher not only sets but also grades all assignments, tests, and examinations of students of the same grade; and, oftentimes the academic standards of the assessments, of all kinds, are set by this teacher alone. This institutionalized practice could certainly be seen as leaving room for manipulation, or even unprofessional practices, by individual teachers: individual teachers would and could make use of such discretion to adjust the level of difficulty for tests and examinations so that they could meet the passing rates and retention rates set by their respective schools. It is not unheard of, and is in fact confirmed in the focus-group interviews with teachers, that some teachers design an extremely easy test paper so that all students could pass so as to avoid potential criticisms by their schools, and that other teachers make a test extremely difficult so that very few students could pass so as to establish the teachers' reputation within their schools. But, this institutionalized practice somehow suggests that teachers are also institutionally trapped: instead of being asked to offer professional judgements in practising grade retention, teachers are essentially expected to play their parts prescribed by the policies of their respective schools.

Meanwhile, teachers are basically seen as an unchallengeable authority in the classroom, which makes the classroom environment in Macao rather coercive. This view is consistent with PISA findings that Macao is one of those participating regions where students are rather negative towards their teachers as well as their schools, as displayed in Figures 1 and 2. Regardless of whether they have been retained or not, students seem to have an equally negative relationship with their teachers and/or schools. But, what should be noted, students who have been retained (M = -0.48, SD = 0.73) devalue more of their schooling experiences than those who have not previously been retained (M = -0.43, SD = 0.78) at statistical significance level of 0.05. Surely, there could be many different reasons for students' negative attitudes towards their teachers and/or schools; but, the point here is that grade retention does not make students direct their discontent towards individual teachers but towards schooling in general. This is actually consistent with the finding for the USA that grade retention does not simply demotivate students or hamper their self-esteem, but makes them more disengaged from school activities (Jimerson & Ferguson, 2007; Jimerson, Pletcher, & Graydon, 2006).

What these practices demonstrate is that grade retention does not necessarily result from students' failure to meet professional academic standards, but from their failure to meet subjective academic requirements set by individual teachers or even their biased judgements against a coercive schooling environment, as a female referred to her observation in a focus-group interview.

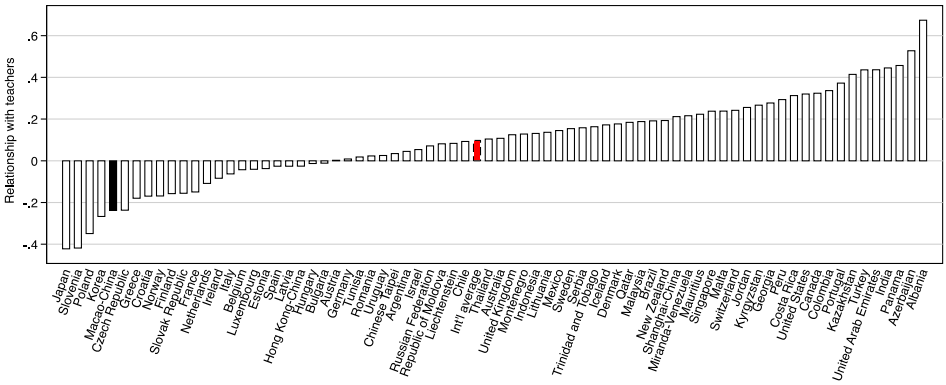

Figure 1. PISA findings – scores on teacher-student relations compared with OECD/international average (Question 26).

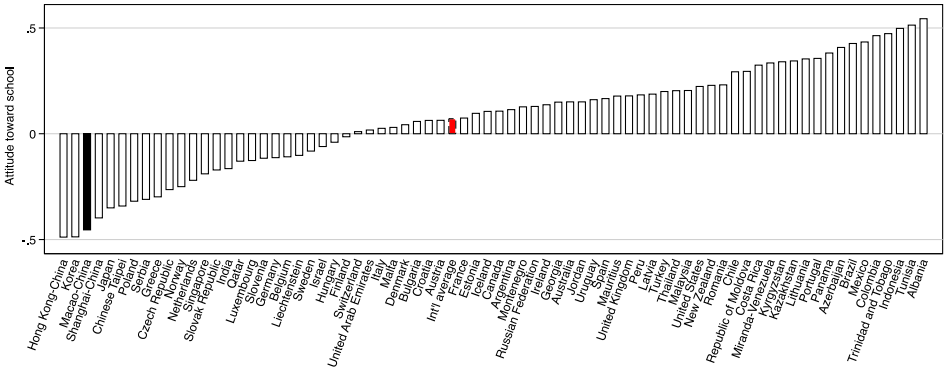

Figure 2. PISA findings – scores on attitude towards schools compared with OECD/international average (Question 33).

> You never know how teachers grade. … Yet, you can't challenge them. I remember, once a classmate of mine got the same answer as mine in a test; but, he got three marks deducted and I got only one. … So, he asked the teacher about that; the teacher said that was how she graded. My classmate simply can't argue with the teacher. … In the end, my classmate was required to repeat another year for he failed English – he needed 1.5 more marks to get a pass. (female student CS8, from a Catholic school)

What should be underscored is this: individual teachers' subjective requirements or biased judgements, thus their unprofessional practices or malpractices, are institutionally sanctioned by their schools in Macao. In other words, contrary to the common belief that grade retention is a synonym for quality assurance of education, grade retention could actually be used by individual teachers as an institutionally sanctioned threat to make students study, so to speak, as a male teacher articulated in a focus-group interview.

> Nowadays every student is entitled to a free and compulsory basic education. These days students just don't cherish the opportunity for education any more. They don't work hard for they don't need to pay for education. No matter what, they could stay on at school for 15 years. I take grade retention as a trump card that could make students work hard. (male teacher TT1, from a school run by a traditional organization, received a local teaching diploma)

Perhaps one could argue that schools in Macao, however coercive they may seem, are collectively upholding some sort of academic standards, even without complying with any common standards, in deciding who should be retained. But, to repeat, Table 3 shows that academic standards are simply not an issue in some cases: in 10 secondary schools academic performance is irrelevant to grade retention, in that students could be retained merely because of their poor conduct. What is at issue is what constitutes a well-behaved student from the perspective of school. Analysing briefly all school

regulations, we find that most schools, of the four types, place a lot of emphasis on students' appearance and behaviour in classroom. Indeed, many students in focus-group interviews complained that too many school regulations were about their appearance and many of such regulations were simply unreasonable. The following quotations are just two examples.

> I think … so many school regulations are related to appearance, and they are just so ridiculous. Basically, with such school uniforms, schools simply want students to look stupid. (male student TS5, from a school run by a traditional organization)

> In our school regulations, there are so many specific requirements about our school uniforms, e.g., the length of our socks and trousers and skirts, the colour of our shoes (what kind of black) and sneakers (what kind of white), the design of our shoes, and even the colour of our bras and underwear. It is rather ridiculous. … And it's a waste of time to make sure that students' hair is so-called 'naturally' black. (female student CS12, from a Catholic school)

And Table 4 reports some typical examples of school regulations from schools of each type about students' behaviour in classroom. It is beyond the scope of this paper to analyse the qualities of students that are intended to be moulded by different types of schools by their respective regulations. Nevertheless, the views expressed by many students in focus-group interviews and regulations reported in Table 4 seem to suggest that qualities that constitute a well-behaved student in most schools in Macao are compliance and obedience.

Certainly, how to define compliance and obedience could be subjective and arbitrary. But, against a schooling context, such characteristics essentially require students not to challenge the authority, including the authority in setting the standards of their academic performance and those of their conduct and in grading them in these aspects. And what this immediately implies is, again, that teachers' unchallengeable authority is sanctioned institutionally by their school. This implication is confirmed further by the views of some students expressed in focus-group interviews.

> Well, I think many teachers are partial. If they like you, you won't have any problems even if you obviously violate a school regulation. … But, teachers would find a way to accuse you of violating school regulations even when you don't. … It's very important to please teachers so as to avoid problems. (female student CS8, from a Catholic school)

> A classmate of mine has his hair touch his collar. A teacher said that he had to have it cut; otherwise, he would be given a demerit for violating a school regulation on the required hair length. The following day that classmate came school with a skin-head and did not violate any school regulations; but he was still punished. The teacher said that the classmate was challenging his authority by such rebellious behaviour. (male student TS2, from a school run by a traditional organization)

In sum, what many students reported in the focus-group interviews lent further support to our argument that the practice of grade retention was readily open to institutionally sanctioned manipulation by individual unprofessional teachers.

Table 4. Examples of school regulations about students' behaviour in the classroom from four types of schools in Macao.

School type	School regulations about students' behaviour in classroom
Government schools	• Respect and obey teachers • Be attentive and obey classroom rules in classes and submit assignments on time • Keep the same seat after being assigned by the form teacher
Schools organized by traditional organizations	• Be quiet in classes, respect teachers, work hard • Get into the classroom immediately after the recess and wait quietly for the next class • Queue up quickly, quietly, and orderly to get off school
Schools organized by the Catholic Church	• Respect and obey Sisters and teaching staff • No sleeping and talking in classes • Be attentive, polite, self-discipline, and cooperative in classes
Other schools	• Be cooperative in classes • Should not read other books or assignments in classes • Should not disturb the class

Source: Wong (2013), Table 7.

Table 5. Proportion of students ever retained by demographic background.

Demographics	Accumulative retention status (%)	
	No, never	Yes, at least once
Gender		
Female	62.6***	37.4%
Male	50.3%	49.6%
Socioeconomic status		
Low	50.8%	49.2%
Medium	55.8%***	44.2%
High	62.8%***	37.2%
Immigration status		
Native	53.9%	46.1%
First generation	55.4%	44.6%
Second generation	58.5%***	41.5%

$^{+}p<0.10$.
$^{*}p<0.05$.
$^{**}p<0.01$.
$^{***}p<0.001$.

Who gets retained in Macao? Why?

This then brings us to discuss who gets retained in Macao and why they get retained. It is commonly believed that academic ability is the basis for grade retention. Given above-mentioned severe competition among private schools, one may suspect that grade retention rate is correlated to the ranking of private schools. But, to repeat, Table 3 already shows that academic performance could be irrelevant to grade retention in Macao; at least it is true of 10 secondary schools in Macao. Although we do not have data on the correlation between grade retention rate and school type or school ranking, PISA data show that grade retention does not happen randomly in Macao. The proportion of students who have been retained is highly correlated to their class background (socio-economic status) and gender (but not immigrant status). Table 5 shows that consistent with what is found in the USA, male students and/or students from families of the lowest socio-economic status are much more likely to get retained than female students and/or students from families of the highest socio-economic status. Immigrant status is not so relevant to the case of Macao perhaps because its immigrants are usually the Chinese from mainland China; although they are still disadvantaged vis-à-vis the locals in terms of accommodating to local life-style and the education system, they basically read the same language, albeit speaking different dialects, and share a similar cultural heritage to the locals'.

While there could be many other reasons for grade retention, the operation of grade retention in Macao discussed above somehow offers a structural perspective on processes underlying the relationship between grade retention and the observed statistical patterns. The discussion above indicates that poor academic grades could result from such institutionally sanctioned practices as individual teachers' unprofessional grading and/or biased judgements of students (including judgements of their failure to comply with school regulations or yield to teachers' authority). It is argued that schools could be seen as an institution where teachers uphold the mainstream standards in judging students of different classes and genders (Aronowitz & Giroux, 1985; Bourdieu, 1984). At the societal level, by compliance, students are required to buy into the promise of qualification for social mobility and thus play the game with the rules, so to speak; and, at the school level, by compliance, students are required to obey school regulations, such as dressing in such a particular manner set by the school, and/or not to challenge teachers' authority, including how teachers grade students' academic performance and/or conduct and how teachers enforce school regulations (Willis, 1981). And, such requirements could lead teachers to have more favourable views of students of an advantaged-class origin or the ethnic dominant group given the students' familiarity with the mainstream standards, and/or female students given the female stereotype of being compliant and submissive (Rothstein, 2004).

To reiterate, we argue that the existing teaching practices in Macao leave much room for institutional manipulation by individual teachers in enforcing school regulations and grading students' conduct and/or academic performances. Given the above-mentioned teachers' views and expectations of students of different classes and genders, male students or students from low socio-economic status families may be judged not to perform well at school at the beginning, may then be graded accordingly, and would finally be more likely to get retained. Such processes are in fact articulated by students or teachers in focus-group interviews. And the processes are consistent with the literature concerning student-teacher interactions in relation to the labelling effects and self-fulfilling prophecy working in the classroom (Metz, 2000), whereby those students initially deviate from teachers' standards, the so-called mainstream standards, and they are then seen as incompliant or disobedient and even incapable by teachers and are subsequently labelled as such. Consequently male and/or disadvantaged-class students would be more likely to be retained because of their poor conduct or academic performances.

Getting retained in Macao, students do not receive any extra academic help; as a result, in repeating a grade, they usually do not do any better academically. On the contrary, it is observed that many of them would do even more poorly. This observation is actually confirmed by the PISA results: Table 6 shows that the PISA score of students are negatively related to grade retention. Contrary to the common view circulated in Macao that grade retention could strengthen students' academic foundation and enhance their performance, we suspect that retention could hamper their subsequent academic performance, which is consistent with what is found for the USA (Silberglitt, Appleton, Burns, & Jimerson, 2006).

While it is documented in the literature that grade retention is closely linked with school dropout, we do not have relevant statistics to demonstrate such a link for Macao. What is known about Macao is only that grade retention rate and the rate of dropping out of high school are both high. Further work is required to see whether a causal relationship between grade retention and school dropout could be established. Surely, there could be many other explanations for high grade retention rate (Wong, 2013) and high dropout rate; for example, the irrelevance of curriculum (mostly borrowed from Taiwan, mainland China, or Hong Kong) to Macao students, the institutionally sanctioned coercive classroom, and the availability of high-paid low-skilled jobs of dealers to the lowly educated resulting from the blooming gambling industry could be plausible explanations. And, we do not mean to pin down one single explanation for grade retention, or argue that grade retention is the only explanation for school dropout. But, we argue, what could strengthen the link between grade retention and school dropout in Macao is perhaps the practice of expelling students who are retained a second time. It is speculated that students who have been retained more than once and then subsequently been kicked out of school would eventually enrol in an evening school in the sector of recurrent education (designed for students aged above 15 failing to complete a basic education in the sector of formal education). This

Table 6. Comparing mean achievement scores between students who have been retained and those who have not.

	Subject		
Repeat grade	Reading	Maths	Science
Do not repeat (reference group)	516.66***	558.75***	539.43***
	(1.28)	(1.31)	(1.25)
Once	−52.28***	−58.39***	−50.03***
	(2.11)	(2.37)	(2.31)
At least twice or more	−95.16***	−106.57***	−88.65***
	(2.84)	(3.20)	(2.91)
At least three times or more	−122.76***	−133.90***	−117.14***
	(7.48)	(8.33)	(7.22)
At least four times or more	−117.86***	−114.25***	−111.85***
	(20.21)	(23.24)	(18.97)
N	5936	5936	5936

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.
$^{+}p<0.10$.
$^{*}p<0.05$.
$^{**}p<0.01$.
$^{***}p<0.001$.

speculation is somehow supported by the fact that the majority of students in the sector of recurrent education are not mature students but students of the relevant age group. From 2008 to 2010 over 70% of students in the sector of recurrent education in Macao are actually aged 15–24 (two categories: aged 15–19 and 20–24); due to official changes in classification by age, since 2010 nearly 50% of them are aged 15–20 (the website of Macao DSEJ). However, in Macao the rate of getting into university or higher education for evening school students is very low and a high school diploma awarded by an evening school is somehow considered inferior to its counterpart awarded by any secondary school in the sector of formal education. In this sense, grade retention in Macao is either leading students to eventually become a school dropout or taking them to an inferior secondary qualification that is unlikely to take them to higher education (cf. Jimerson, 1999; Weis, Farrar, & Petrie, 1989). Either way, grade retention is leading students to a lower level of educational attainment.

The specific operation of grade retention in relation to different sectors of the Macao education system – the sector of formal education (i.e., day schools) and the sector of recurrent education (i.e., evening schools) – is beyond the scope of this paper and would be dealt with elsewhere. But the point here is that consistent with other school practices such as tracking and ability-grouping, the practice of grade retention is found working against male students of a low socio-economic status family, in that in the name of meritocratic selection this practice may take more of these students to a lower educational attainment through dropping them out of the sector of formal education, or to an inferior secondary qualification through channelling them to the sector of recurrent education. In this way, grade retention, with its specific operation in Macao, could be seen as serving as a mechanism for social differentiation contributing to the observed class and gender gap in educational attainment.

Conclusion

In this paper, we sought to fill in a gap in the studies on grade retention whereby it was basically taken as an intervention strategy for improving student learning rather than a social mechanism for understanding the observed patterns of educational inequality. In doing so, we also sought to be one of the first addressing the situation in an Asian context using Macao as a case study. More specifically, the case of Macao was meant to provide a contextualized structural illustration for the operation of grade retention showing how the institutional manipulation of the practice of grade retention by private schools as well as their teachers could play a part in educational inequality.

To this end, we drew on some data from PISA 2009 and part of a qualitative research project. What was found was that grade retention in Macao did not happen randomly; rather, consistent with the observed patterns of educational inequality for many industrial-capitalist societies, male and/or disadvantaged-class students in Macao were more likely to get retained. What should be understood are the following two points: first, as implied by most school regulations in Macao, thus shaping teachers' standards of judgements, compliance and obedience are seen as two important qualities expected of students that are crucial to the grading of students' academic performance and conduct; and second, the enforcement of school regulations and the existing teaching practices in Macao leave much room for institutionally sanctioned manipulation by teachers. With such expectations of students or grading standards, male and/or disadvantaged-class students were presumably judged more unfavourably than their female and/or advantaged-class counterparts. This then explained why male and/or disadvantaged-class students were more likely to be labelled by teachers as problematic students in the first place; and, in view of teachers' unchallengeable authority and thus the possibility for their institutionally sanctioned manipulation in enforcing school regulations, given the criteria for grade retention set by many schools, it became apparent why male and/or disadvantaged-class students were eventually more likely to get retained.

While arguing that the education leaves room for institutionally sanctioned manipulation by teachers, we by no means seek to reduce our argument on this structural manoeuvre down to the personality traits or characteristics of particular individual teachers. Neither do we overlook the fact that there are many teachers who are empathetic with students or understand the ineffectiveness of grade retention

as an intervention strategy. Rather, we seek to offer a structural understanding on how such so-called teachers' malpractice could be institutionally sanctioned and then play a role in grade retention.

And then, given available PISA data, we sought to make informed speculation that grade retention could hamper students' subsequent academic performances. This negative effect, together with a common practice of expelling students who are retained a second time, forced many students who had been retained either to end their educational career or to leave the sector of formal education and enrol in the sector of recurrent education. More statistics and relevant analyses are required before the respective causal relationships between grade retention and school dropout, and between grade retention and enrolment in an evening school for Macao could be established. But, either becoming a school dropout or obtaining an inferior high school diploma that was unlikely to take them to a higher qualification, retained students – most of them being male and/or disadvantaged-class students – would eventually be likely to attain a lower level of qualification than their promoted counterparts. This then illustrated how the practice of grade retention could serve as a mechanism for social differentiation playing a role in producing educational inequality in Macao.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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